Hearing Threshold Shifts: HR Classification & Follow-up Guide

For the fourteen reported shifts from the deboning lines: classify only after reviewing the audiograms. No worker-level outcome can be decided from the count of reported shifts alone.

1. STS A standard threshold shift (STS) is a comparison result—not automatically a recordable case.	**2. Recordability** A separate OSHA recordkeeping decision with additional conditions.	**3. Follow-up** Hearing conservation duties can apply even when the 300 Log does not.

Key terms in plain language

Baseline	the audiogram against which later thresholds are compared. Verify the correct worker, ear, date, and applicable prior audiogram before calculating any shift.
STS	for each ear separately, an average worsening of 10 dB or more at 2,000, 3,000, and 4,000 Hz compared with the baseline. Either ear can meet the rule; both ears do not have to.
Recordable hearing-loss case	a work-related, persistent/permanent STS that also shows an average total hearing level of 25 dB or more above audiometric zero at 2,000, 3,000, and 4,000 Hz in the same ear.

Decision sequence — use this order

1 VERIFY Match the worker, ear, test date, baseline, and applicable prior audiogram; check that the comparison is usable.
2 CALCULATE For each ear, average the change at 2/3/4 kHz. Is worsening 10 dB or more? If yes, it is an STS.
3 CONFIRM The employer may retest within 30 days of the initial audiogram. Use the retest to determine whether the shift is confirmed; do not treat the initial result as final while that permitted window is being assessed.
4 RECORD? For a final case, check separately: work-relatedness; persistence/permanence (not returned to baseline in the applicable assessment); and average total hearing level 25 dB or more above audiometric zero in the same ear. Record only when all apply.
5 ACT Complete worker notice and hearing-conservation follow-up for an STS; complete OSHA recordkeeping only for a qualifying recordable case.

REQUIREMENT — age correction. For OSHA recordkeeping, the employer may use the age-correction tables in 29 CFR 1910.95 Appendix F when determining whether the recordability criteria are met. It is a limited permitted consideration—not a universal subtraction, not a substitute for the baseline comparison, and not a reason to skip the separate STS, 25 dB, work-relatedness, and persistence checks.

Employer Duties, Quality Checks & Safe Escalation

Use the labels below deliberately: **REQUIREMENT** = federal OSHA duty; **CAUTION** = do not make a premature classification; **REVIEW** = occupational-health/audiology assessment.

Required actions after the determination

STS notice	REQUIREMENT — Notify the employee in writing within 21 days after the STS is determined. Inform the employee of the result and the need for hearing-protection/hearing-conservation follow-up as applicable.
Protection	REQUIREMENT — When hearing-conservation requirements apply, provide and make hearing protectors available. Fit, refit, training, and actual use matter; handing over earplugs alone is not enough.
Exposure	REQUIREMENT — Include employees exposed at or above an 85 dBA 8-hour time-weighted average (TWA) in the hearing conservation program. REVIEW — revisit exposure assessment and controls when shifts or conditions suggest a problem.
OSHA log	REQUIREMENT — Enter a qualifying recordable case on the OSHA Form 300 Log within 7 calendar days after the case is determined. An STS by itself is not an automatic log entry.
Records	REQUIREMENT — Retain audiometric records and supporting documentation under OSHA retention rules. Audiometric test records are retained for the affected employee's employment; employee medical records are retained for employment plus 30 years where 29 CFR 1910.1020 applies.

Do not let the baseline or test quality decide the case by convenience

REQUIREMENT — baseline revision. Do not revise a baseline merely to make a shift disappear. An annual audiogram may replace the baseline only when the audiologist, otolaryngologist, or physician determines that the STS is persistent; use another revision basis only if the governing requirement permits it.

CAUTION — quality first. Inadequate quiet before testing, poor test conditions/equipment, or a temporary conductive issue can distort a comparison. Do not treat that result as settled; arrange review or permitted retesting before final classification.

REVIEW — professional follow-up. Seek occupational-health or audiology review for questionable test quality, a possible temporary medical condition, persistent shift, referral criteria, or uncertainty about work-relatedness. Threshold data do not diagnose a condition or establish benefits.

Two generic ambiguity reminders (not findings for any worker)

Case A	A 10 dB STS can exist but still fail the separate 25 dB hearing-level-above-audiometric-zero criterion; it is not automatically recordable.
Case B	A questionable initial result may require quality review or the permitted 30-day retest; it is not automatically confirmed or erased.

Classification-and-duty summary

For each reported shift: verify the record and test quality; calculate STS ear-by-ear; consider the 30-day retest; then make the distinct recordability decision using the 25 dB criterion, work-relatedness, and persistence/permanence. Give timely written STS notice and protection/program follow-up as applicable. Log only a qualifying case. Send unresolved facts to occupational health/audiology—do not assign a worker-specific result without the audiogram and review.

Authority snapshot: 29 CFR 1904.10; 29 CFR 1910.95(g), (i), (m) and Appendix F; 29 CFR 1910.1020. Federal OSHA framework current as of December 31, 2024.